

ASSIGNMENT BRIEF — STRATEGIC HUMAN RESOURCE MANAGEMENT
Department of Public Administration, IUB

ASSIGNMENT BRIEF

IBM's Global Talent Management Strategy: The Vision of the Globally Integrated Enterprise

Case Study (Parts A, B & C) — SHRM / John W. Boudreau, Ph.D.

Case Study	IBM's Global Talent Management Strategy: The Vision of the Globally Integrated Enterprise
Source	SHRM Case Study (Parts A, B & C) — John W. Boudreau, Ph.D.
Course Level	MS Public Administration — Strategic Human Resource Management
Instructor	Dr. Arsalan Rasool, Assistant Professor
Total Marks	30 points (Word Document: 20 pts PowerPoint: 10 pts)
Submission Due	[08-06-2026]
Format	Individual Assignment Two deliverables required

1. Assignment Overview

This assignment is based on the three-part case study series IBM's Global Talent Management Strategy: The Vision of the Globally Integrated Enterprise, written by John W. Boudreau, Ph.D., and published by the Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM). The case traces IBM's ambitious Workforce Management Initiative (WMI) — from its strategic vision in 2003, through the design and implementation of the Expertise Taxonomy, to the redesign of IBM's global HR organization.

Across Parts A, B, and C, the case examines how IBM confronted the challenge of managing a globally integrated enterprise of approximately 350,000 employees, 90,000 contractors, and tens of thousands of applicants, deploying principles borrowed from supply chain management to create what became a living, breathing global talent market.

You will produce two deliverables that demonstrate critical analysis, clear argumentation, and professional presentation skills appropriate for a human resource management audience.

- **Deliverable 1: A professional Word Document (analytical policy report)**
- **Deliverable 2: A PowerPoint Presentation (executive briefing)**

Both deliverables must demonstrate critical analysis, clear argumentation, and professional presentation standards appropriate for a human resource management audience.

2. Learning Outcomes

Upon completing this assignment, you will be able to:

- Analyze the strategic and organizational context that led IBM to develop the Workforce Management Initiative (WMI).
- Evaluate the design and implementation of IBM's Expertise Taxonomy as a tool for global talent management.
- Critically assess the effectiveness, limitations, and equity implications of IBM's globally integrated HR model.
- Construct a well-reasoned HR management argument supported by evidence drawn from all three parts of the case.
- Communicate complex strategic HRM analysis in both written and visual formats for a professional executive audience.
- Reflect on the transferability of IBM's WMI model to other large multinational organizations.

3. Deliverable 1 — Word Document: Analytical HRM Report

3.1 Purpose

You are to write a structured analytical report that examines the IBM case study in depth across all three parts (A, B, and C), evaluates the WMI and the globally integrated HR model, and makes an evidence-based recommendation regarding the replicability or adaptation of this approach. Your audience is a senior HR executive or organizational leader with no prior familiarity with this specific case.

3.2 Required Structure & Minimum Word Counts

Your document must follow the structure below. Sections falling below the minimum word count will be penalized.

Section	Content Description	Min. Words	Case Study Reference
Executive Summary	Concise overview of findings and recommendation (written last, placed first)	200	All Parts
1. Introduction	Background on IBM's strategic context, the GIE vision, and the purpose of the report	250	Part A
2. Strategic & Historical Analysis	Evolution of IBM's workforce challenges (2003), the WMI vision, and the decision to invest over US\$100 million	400	Parts A & B
3. System Design & Implementation	The Expertise Taxonomy: structure, governance, limitations of prior approaches (job descriptions, competencies), and lessons from contractors	450	Part B
4. Stakeholder Analysis	Identify and evaluate the interests of senior HR leadership, business unit managers, employees, contractors, and external labor suppliers	350	Parts A, B & C
5. Critical Evaluation	Assess the WMI model: successes (utilization rates, financial ROI), limitations, equity concerns, accountability, and future challenges	450	Parts B & C

Section	Content Description	Min. Words	Case Study Reference
6. Policy Recommendation	A clearly argued recommendation on whether this model should be replicated, adapted, or rejected in other large organizations	300	Parts B & C
7. Conclusion	Synthesis of key insights and implications for HRM practice in globally integrated enterprises	150	All Parts
8. References	Minimum 6 academic or policy sources (APA or Chicago style)	—	—

Total minimum word count: 2,350 words (excluding references and executive summary). There is no maximum word count; however, concise and well-argued writing is valued over length.

3.3 Formatting Guidelines

Your report must meet all of the following formatting standards:

Page Layout

- Paper size: A4
- Margins: 2.54 cm (1 inch) on all sides
- Page numbers: bottom-right of every page, starting from page 1
- Header: Include your name, student ID, and course code on every page

Typography

- Body text font: Times New Roman or Calibri, 12pt; Arial 11pt
- Headings: Bold, 14pt for section headings; 12pt bold for sub-headings
- Line spacing: 1.5 throughout the body
- Paragraph spacing: Add 6pt spacing after each paragraph (do not insert blank lines between paragraphs)

Professional Standards

- Use consistent heading numbering (e.g., 1, 1.1, 1.2, 2, 2.1 ...)
- All tables and figures must be captioned and numbered (e.g., "Table 1: Stakeholder Interests")
- All in-text citations must correspond to a full reference in the bibliography
- Use formal, third-person academic writing throughout
- Avoid bullet points in the body of the report — use full prose paragraphs
- Proofread carefully; significant grammar and spelling errors will affect your grade

3.4 Marking Criteria — Word Document (20 points)

Criterion	Weight	Excellent (90–100%)	Satisfactory (60–79%)	Needs Work (<60%)
Critical Analysis	8 pts	Insightful analysis with nuanced argument; draws on all three parts of the case and relevant theory.	Adequate analysis; some generalization; limited use of evidence from the full case.	Descriptive summary only; no critical engagement; relies on one part of the case.

Criterion	Weight	Excellent (90–100%)	Satisfactory (60–79%)	Needs Work (<60%)
HRM Argument & Recommendation	5 pts	Clear, well-evidenced recommendation with acknowledgement of limitations and transferability conditions.	Recommendation present but weakly supported; limited consideration of context.	No clear recommendation or argument; descriptive only.
Stakeholder Analysis	3 pts	All key stakeholders identified with competing interests clearly articulated and connected to the WMI design.	Main stakeholders covered; interests partially explored.	Stakeholders missing or analysis superficial.
Structure & Clarity	2 pts	Logical flow; professional prose; smooth transitions between sections; all seven sections present.	Generally clear with some structural gaps or missing sections.	Disorganized; hard to follow; sections missing.
Formatting & Citations	2 pts	Fully compliant with all guidelines; consistent and correct referencing; minimum 6 sources.	Minor deviations from guidelines; referencing mostly correct.	Multiple formatting errors; citations missing or incorrect.

4. Deliverable 2 — PowerPoint Presentation: Executive Briefing

4.1 Purpose

You will create a professional PowerPoint presentation that summarizes your findings and recommendation from the Word document. Imagine you are presenting to IBM's senior leadership team or at an HR management conference. Your audience is informed but time-constrained — your slides must be clear, engaging, and well-designed.

4.2 Slide Requirements

Your presentation must contain a minimum of 12 slides and a maximum of 18 slides, structured as follows:

- Slide 1 — Title Slide: Include your name, student ID, course code, date, and the case title.
- Slide 2 — Agenda / Roadmap: Outline what the presentation will cover.
- Slides 3–4 — Case Background: IBM's strategic context in 2003, the GIE vision, and the evidence that change was needed (utilization rates, talent gaps, disconnected talent pools).
- Slides 5–6 — The WMI & Expertise Taxonomy: The WMI vision, the Taxonomy structure (PJC, SJC, JR, JRSS, Skills), and how it addressed prior limitations of job descriptions and competency frameworks.
- Slides 7–8 — Stakeholder Analysis: Visualize key actors and their interests using a chart, diagram, or table.
- Slides 9–10 — Critical Evaluation: Strengths (financial ROI, utilization rates, employment brand), limitations, and future challenges raised in Part C.
- Slides 11–12 — Policy / HRM Recommendation: Your recommendation with clear rationale and any conditions or caveats.
- Slide 13 — Conclusion: Key takeaways and implications for HRM in globally integrated enterprises.
- Slide 14 — References: List all sources cited in the presentation.
- Slides 15–18 (optional): Supplementary data, additional case comparisons, or Q&A buffer slides.

4.3 Design & Formatting Guidelines

Layout & Visual Standards

- Use a consistent slide theme and color palette throughout — do not mix unrelated templates.
- Every content slide must include at least one visual element: a chart, photograph, icon, map, diagram, or data callout.
- Do not use text-only slides — walls of text will be penalized.
- Maintain a minimum 0.5" margin from all slide edges.
- Slide dimensions: Widescreen 16:9 (33.87 cm × 19.05 cm) is strongly preferred.

Typography

- Slide title font size: minimum 36pt, bold.
- Body text font size: minimum 18pt — text smaller than 18pt is not legible in a projected setting.
- Use no more than two font families across the entire presentation.
- Left-align body text; center-align titles only.

Content Discipline

- Maximum 6 bullet points per slide. Each bullet should be a key idea, not a full sentence.
- Use the "6×6 rule" as a guide: no more than 6 words per bullet, no more than 6 bullets per slide.
- Speaker notes are required for slides 3–13. Each notes section must contain at least 3 full sentences elaborating on the slide content.
- Cite your sources on each slide where data or direct claims are used (small font at the bottom of the slide is acceptable).

Professionalism

- All images must be high-resolution and appropriately credited.
- Avoid clip art, low-quality stock photos, or irrelevant decorative elements.
- Spell-check all text. Typos on slides are highly visible and will affect your grade.
- Do not animate text entry — simple and purposeful transitions only (e.g., Fade between slides).

4.4 Marking Criteria — PowerPoint Presentation (10 points)

Criterion	Weight	Excellent (90–100%)	Satisfactory (60–79%)	Needs Work (<60%)
Content & Accuracy	4 pts	Accurate, well-selected content that faithfully represents all three parts of the case and supports the argument.	Most content accurate; some gaps or minor misrepresentations; not all parts of the case referenced.	Key facts missing or incorrect; weak connection to case; only one or two parts referenced.
Visual Design	2 pts	Polished, consistent design; every slide has a purposeful visual element; professional color palette.	Visually adequate; some slides lack visual elements or feel inconsistent.	Poor design; text-heavy; no clear visual identity; templates mixed randomly.
Speaker Notes	2 pts	Detailed, well-written notes on every required slide — could serve as a full presentation script.	Notes present but thin; some required slides missing notes.	Notes absent or too brief to be useful.
Structure & Flow	2 pts	Clear, logical narrative from opening to conclusion; smooth transitions; all required slides present.	Generally clear structure with minor gaps in flow; one or two required slides missing.	Slides feel disconnected; no clear narrative arc; required slides absent.

5. Submission Instructions

- Submit both files via the link provided by your course instructor by [08-06-2026].
- File naming convention:
- **LastName_FirstName_StudentID_IBMTalentMgmt_Report.docx**
- **LastName_FirstName_StudentID_IBMTalentMgmt_Slides.pptx**
- Late submissions will be penalized at a rate of 5 marks per 24-hour period unless an extension has been approved in writing by the instructor at least 48 hours before the deadline.
- Both deliverables must be submitted together. Submitting only one will result in the missing component receiving zero marks.

6. Academic Integrity

All submitted work must be your own. You are required to read and comply with the university's Academic Integrity Policy. In particular:

- Cite the case study in all submissions as: Boudreau, J. W. (2010). IBM's Global Talent Management Strategy: The Vision of the Globally Integrated Enterprise (Parts A, B & C). Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM).
- The use of AI writing tools (e.g., ChatGPT) to generate your report or slide content is not permitted. Paraphrasing AI-generated text is also prohibited.
- Plagiarism detection software will be applied to all submissions. A similarity score above 20% (excluding the reference list) may result in an academic misconduct investigation.

7. Guidance & Support

The following resources are available to support your work:

- The three-part case study (Parts A, B, and C) are your primary sources. Read all three in full before beginning — each part addresses distinct aspects of the WMI.
- Supplement the case with at least 5 additional academic sources on global talent management, workforce planning, HR analytics, or globally integrated enterprises.
- Office hours: [10:00 am to 02:00 pm]. Students are strongly encouraged to discuss their recommendation before finalizing the report.
- The university library databases are available for research and writing support.

Suggested additional readings (not exhaustive):

- Boudreau, J. W., & Ramstad, P. M. (2007). *Beyond HR: The New Science of Human Capital*. Harvard Business School Press.
- Cappelli, P. (2008). *Talent on Demand: Managing Talent in an Age of Uncertainty*. Harvard Business Publishing.
- Lawler, E. E., III, & Boudreau, J. W. (2009). *Achieving Excellence in Human Resources Management*. Stanford University Press.
- Palmisano, S. J. (2006). The globally integrated enterprise. *Foreign Affairs*, 85(3), 127–136.

8. Discussion Prompts to Guide Your Analysis

Consider the following questions as you develop your report and presentation. You do not need to address all of them, but they are designed to stimulate critical thinking:

- What factors contributed to the success of IBM's WMI? Could these factors be replicated in a different organizational or national context?

- What are the strengths and limitations of the supply chain metaphor as applied to talent management? Does it risk reducing employees to interchangeable parts?
- How did IBM resolve the tension between standardization (a unified Taxonomy) and customization (country-specific needs and exceptions)?
- The WMI generated approximately US\$1.5 billion in benefits from a US\$230 million investment. What were the most significant sources of financial return, and were some underestimated?
- IBM's "dual-hatting" model in Part C blended HR functional leadership with business partnership. What are the advantages and risks of this structural approach?
- How should IBM — or any globally integrated enterprise — maintain the "soft" human side of employment relationships when managing talent through data-driven analytics?
- If you were advising the CHRO of a large multinational considering a similar initiative, what conditions would you set before recommending adoption?

9. Final Submission Checklist

Word Document

- ☐ Executive Summary, all 7 numbered sections, and reference list included
- ☐ Total word count meets the 2,350-word minimum
- ☐ Correct fonts, margins, line spacing, and page numbering applied
- ☐ All headings numbered consistently
- ☐ In-text citations present for every external claim
- ☐ Minimum 6 references in correct citation style (APA or Chicago)
- ☐ File saved as .docx with correct file name

PowerPoint Presentation

- ☐ Minimum 12 slides included in the required order
- ☐ Each content slide contains at least one visual element
- ☐ Text is no smaller than 18pt on any content slide
- ☐ Speaker notes included for slides 3–13 (3+ sentences each)
- ☐ Sources cited on all data or claim slides
- ☐ Consistent color palette and font scheme throughout
- ☐ Spell-checked and proofread
- ☐ File saved as .pptx with correct file name

Good luck! Strong HRM analysis begins with asking the right questions — and the courage to argue for your answer.